

Honest A\$\$%\$#%&

What you see above is an example of self-censorship. We do this all the time. We side-step, duck, dodge and altogether avoid absolutely anything that can be construed as a “sensitive topic”. And let’s face it, it’s not always the fear of hurting someone’s feelings that causes self-censorship, it’s also a fear of being the one who gets hurt!

Most of you don’t know this (unless you’ve met me), but I actually have a rather unfiltered connection between my brain and mouth. If you overheard me speaking to friends or colleagues, I’m pretty sure I’d offend some of your sensibilities (if not all). It’s because I’m an “Honest A\$\$%\$#%&”, and am not ashamed to admit it. I speak my mind, but also encourage others to do the same, especially those who disagree with me. I don’t have to like what you’re saying in order to pay attention or listen – I’m not some TV news anchor or politician with an agenda.

However, as events over the past few years have shown, people are quick to take offense at just about anything. That’s fine too; if you want to go about life being a stuck-up, angry, hate-spewing person, who am I to judge you? Your thoughts are yours alone, your actions, however...Thoughts shouldn’t be policed, actions that affect others, have to be. Words, however, in my book, are thoughts, not actions. Easier said than done, obviously, but it’s what we should aim for as a society.

To clarify, I’m not talking about censorship and threats from terrorists or religious zealots, which is all just politics and the power hungry struggling to control the masses, as far as I’m concerned. I’m talking about the good guys, our knights in shining armour, our saviours and protectors – governments and all the mega corporations we put so much trust in (even if not by choice).

It’s fast becoming a not-so-private world. For example, the idea of sharing your life events with close family is long dead and gone. It’s now about sharing with the world...at least anything you’re proud of, because anything you’re ashamed of you try to bury as deep as possible.

We’re human, and what makes us human is the fact that we have an opinion. You express that opinion in the ways of today, which currently happen to be your Facebook or Twitter account, Reddit, blogs, whatever. Some of us use our real names and are proud of taking stands,

some prefer the cover of relative anonymity so that they can be less bothered about what others feel (and not get beat up, presumably).

I had an argument with an anti-feminist friend on a social network over a feminist status update I made, which was set to public (as almost all my posts are). When he realised this, he asked me to remove the original post/delete all his posts, because “Never know which stupid HR chick/dude does what silly background check” (and presumably gets the wrong impression). The premise was that people don’t have the maturity to be able to take what you say in the right spirit.

Now I don’t know about all this. I’ve always been a what-you-see-is-what-you-get type of person, flaws and all (especially the flaws). I can’t for the life of me fathom how people might be living dual (or more?) lives and playing different characters at home, at work, with friends, etc. I’d rather miss out on opportunities that (or people who) don’t appreciate the fact that everyone has flaws and eccentricities, and that’s what makes everyone special.

If a company doesn’t want to hire me because I’m openly feminist, or atheist, or outspoken, or an honest a\$\$%\$#%&, I’d probably not enjoy working there anyway...

I can talk to and convince my friends to be more open, but how do you do that with a government or people in power or corporations? You don’t talk to them, you talk about them, you spread awareness. Don’t be afraid to speak your mind, and encourage or even defend others who speak their minds, especially when it’s a view contrary to your own, or goes against popular opinion. As Evelyn Beatrice Hall said, “I disapprove of what you say, but I will defend to the death your right to say it.”

Here’s to a utopian future where we’re all openly honest assholes, can stop self-censoring, and don’t get killed, jailed, beaten up or threatened for merely speaking our minds. Meanwhile, this month’s cover story lives squarely in the present and tells you how to thumb your nose at the censorship you’ll face until then... 



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“Thoughts shouldn’t be policed, actions that affect others, have to be”

Liked or hated this column?
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and let me know your thoughts.